



POCKET GUIDE

The First 24 Hours

You've decided something has to change. A calm, step-by-step guide for finding help today - what to do, who to call, and how to get through tonight.

ClearBedRecovery.com

Important

This guide is about starting the process of finding help. It is **not** medical advice, diagnosis, treatment, detox guidance, or a treatment plan.

Start here: what this guide is

This is a calm first-day guide for finding help, making calls, and getting through tonight. It is not a detox plan and does not tell you how to start, stop, or change any substance, medication, or treatment.

If there is immediate danger

Call **911** now for a medical emergency, overdose concern, danger to yourself or someone else, or any situation that cannot safely wait. For a mental health, suicide, or substance-use crisis, call or text **988** for 24/7 crisis support in the U.S.

Today is not about solving your whole life. Today is about creating enough safety and clarity to take the next step.

The only three priorities

1	Safety Make the next few hours safer. Get out of isolation and call emergency help if needed.
2	Connection Tell one safe person what is happening. You do not need to explain everything.
3	Next call Contact a treatment provider, helpline, doctor, therapist, or trusted support.

Tiny first step

- [] Charge your phone.
- [] Sit somewhere safe and visible, not hidden away.
- [] Send one text asking someone to stay reachable tonight.
- [] Open ClearBedRecovery.com or a trusted treatment locator and write down 2-3 options.

Hour 0-2: get grounded and tell one person

The goal of the first two hours is not perfection. It is to interrupt panic, secrecy, and decision overload.

Text you can copy

I need help starting the process today. I am safe right now, but I do not want to do this alone. Can you stay available while I make a few calls?

Do these before researching for hours

- [] Move to a safer place: living room, porch, friend's house, church, public place, or with family.
- [] Tell one person you trust: spouse, parent, sponsor, pastor, friend, counselor, or recovery contact.
- [] Write down what you are looking for: detox assessment, residential, PHP, IOP, outpatient, MAT, mental health care, or family guidance.
- [] Avoid arguing, doom scrolling, or trying to make every decision tonight.

If you are helping someone

Stay calm. Ask one question at a time. Offer to sit with them while they call. Do not turn the first conversation into a lecture, interrogation, or punishment.

Hour 2-6: gather the basics

Most treatment calls are easier if you have basic information nearby. You do not need every answer before calling.

Have this ready if you can

- [] Full name, date of birth, phone number, and current location.
- [] Insurance card or Medicaid/Medicare information, if available.
- [] Main concern: substance use, alcohol, opioids, mental health, dual diagnosis, family crisis, or something else.
- [] Current medications and major medical/mental health concerns.
- [] Transportation limits, work/childcare needs, and whether same-day help is needed.
- [] A safe callback number and a person who can help you remember what was said.

Do not wait for perfect information

If you are overwhelmed, call anyway and say: "I do not know what level of care I need. I need help figuring out the next step."

Write it down

Insurance _____

Trusted person _____

Safe callback # _____

Hour 6-12: make the right calls

You are not trying to find the perfect facility in one call. You are trying to move from confusion to a short list of real next steps.

Who to contact

1	Emergency support Call 911 if anyone is in immediate danger. Call/text 988 for mental health, suicide, or substance-use crisis support.
2	Treatment information Use trusted resources such as ClearBedRecovery.com , FindTreatment.gov , or SAMHSA's National Helpline at 1-800-662-HELP (4357).
3	Direct providers Call facilities directly and ask what level of care they offer, what insurance they accept, and what the next step would be.

Opening line for a facility call

Hi, I am trying to find help today. I am not sure what level of care is right. Can someone in admissions ask a few questions and explain the next step?

If you are calling for someone else

I am helping someone I care about look for treatment options. I need to understand what information you need, what level of care you provide, and how to verify insurance or costs.

Questions to ask before choosing

Use this list to compare options without getting lost. You do not have to ask every question in one call.

Facility questions

- ☐ Are you the facility/provider directly, or a referral service?
- ☐ What levels of care do you offer: detox, residential, PHP, IOP, outpatient, MAT, mental health, dual diagnosis?
- ☐ Do you accept my exact insurance plan? What should I expect for out-of-pocket costs?
- ☐ Is an assessment available today or tomorrow? Is there a waitlist?
- ☐ What documents do I need: ID, insurance card, medication list, prescriptions, discharge papers?
- ☐ Who is the admissions contact and direct phone number?
- ☐ What happens if you are not the right fit? Can you suggest the next appropriate resource?

Red flags

Pressure, vague answers about costs, unclear facility identity, refusal to explain where your information goes, or promises that sound too certain. Slow down and verify.

Hour 12-24: get through tonight

Tonight's job is to stay connected and keep the process moving. This is not a detox plan. If symptoms, cravings, withdrawal concerns, or mental health symptoms feel unsafe, contact emergency/crisis help or a qualified professional immediately.

Build a simple tonight plan

- ☐ One person who knows what is going on and can answer the phone.
- ☐ One safe place to be tonight.
- ☐ One facility, helpline, counselor, sponsor, pastor, or doctor to contact tomorrow.
- ☐ One thing you will avoid tonight because it makes things worse.
- ☐ One small thing you can do next: shower, eat, sleep, charge phone, write notes, or sit with someone safe.

Fill this in

Safe person _____

Where I will be _____

First call tomorrow _____

What I will avoid _____

Repeat this if panic hits

I do not have to solve everything tonight. I only have to stay safe, stay connected, and take the next right step.

For families and support people

You may be scared, angry, tired, or confused. The goal in the first day is to help the person move toward real support without making the moment more chaotic.

Say this

- [] I am glad you told me.
- [] We do not have to figure it all out this second.
- [] Can I sit with you while we call someone?
- [] Let's write down the next two steps.
- [] If you feel unsafe, I am calling emergency or crisis help.

Avoid this

- [] Do not argue about the entire past tonight.
- [] Do not promise a specific treatment outcome.
- [] Do not rely on one random listing without verifying the facility, insurance, and admissions contact.
- [] Do not leave someone alone if they may harm themselves or others.

Your role

Be calm, specific, and practical. Help reduce the number of decisions. Offer to call, drive, sit nearby, write notes, or help compare options.

Your first-day checklist

Check off what you can. Leave the rest. This page is for progress, not perfection.

- ☐ I told one safe person what is happening.
- ☐ I wrote down my immediate concern and what kind of help I may need.
- ☐ I gathered insurance/ID/phone information if available.
- ☐ I identified at least two treatment or support options to contact.
- ☐ I asked direct questions about insurance, level of care, costs, and next steps.
- ☐ I made a simple tonight plan.
- ☐ I know when to call 911 or 988 if safety changes.
- ☐ I wrote down the next call or appointment.

Next call/appointment

Name _____

Phone _____

Date/time _____

What to ask _____

ClearBed reminder

Use ClearBedRecovery.com to search treatment options and compare facility details more clearly. Verify important details directly with the provider before making decisions.

Disclaimer and trusted resources

Not medical advice

This pocket guide is for general education and decision support only. It is not medical advice, diagnosis, treatment, detox guidance, a treatment plan, or a substitute for care from a qualified professional. Always verify information directly with providers and emergency/crisis services.

Trusted resources

Emergency: Call 911 for immediate medical danger, overdose concern, violence, or danger to self/others.

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: Call or text 988 for 24/7 mental health, suicide, or substance-use crisis support in the U.S.

SAMHSA National Helpline: 1-800-662-HELP (4357) provides free, confidential, 24/7, 365-day treatment referral and information support in English and Spanish.

FindTreatment.gov: SAMHSA's confidential and anonymous resource for people seeking mental health or substance use treatment in the U.S. and territories.

ClearBedRecovery.com: Search and compare treatment options with clearer facility information. ClearBed is not a medical provider and does not provide treatment.

Sources

- SAMHSA 988 Lifeline information and key messages: [samhsa.gov/mental-health/988](https://www.samhsa.gov/mental-health/988)
- SAMHSA helplines: [samhsa.gov/find-help/helplines](https://www.samhsa.gov/find-help/helplines) and [samhsa.gov/find-help/helplines/national-helpline](https://www.samhsa.gov/find-help/helplines/national-helpline)
- FindTreatment.gov: [findtreatment.samhsa.gov](https://www.findtreatment.samhsa.gov)
- SAMHSA treatment locators: [samhsa.gov/find-help/locators](https://www.samhsa.gov/find-help/locators)

